THE CORSICAN CONNECTION

How to solve the alignment problem? In theory, when humans create a computer network, they must define for it an ultimate goal, which the computers are never allowed to change or ignore. Then, even if computers become so powerful that we lose control over them, we can rest assured that their immense power will benefit rather than harm us. Unless, of course, it turned out that we defined a harmful or vague goal. And there's the rub. In the case of human networks, we rely on self-correcting mechanisms to periodically review and revise our goals, so setting the wrong goal is not the end of the world. But since the computer network might escape our control, if we set it the wrong goal, we might discover our mistake when we are no longer able to correct it. Some might hope that through a careful process of deliberation, we might be able to define in advance the right goals for the computer network. This, however, is a very dangerous delusion.

To understand why it is impossible to agree in advance on the ultimate goals of the computer network, let's revisit Clausewitz's war theory. There is one fatal flaw in the way he equates rationality with alignment. While Clausewitzian theory demands that all actions be aligned with the ultimate goal, it offers no rational way to define such a goal. Consider Napoleon's life and military career. What should have been his ultimate goal? Given the prevailing cultural atmosphere of France *c.* 1800, we can think of several alternatives for 'ultimate goal' that might have occurred to Napoleon:

POTENTIAL GOAL NUMBER 1: Making France the dominant power in Europe, secure against any future attack by Britain, the Habsburg Empire, Russia, a unified Germany or a unified Italy.

POTENTIAL GOAL NUMBER 2: Creating a new multiethnic empire ruled by Napoleon's family, which would include not only France but also many additional territories both in Europe and overseas.

POTENTIAL GOAL NUMBER 3: Achieving everlasting glory for himself personally, so that even centuries after his death billions of people will know the name Napoleon and admire his genius.

POTENTIAL GOAL NUMBER 4: Securing the redemption of his everlasting soul and gaining entry to heaven after his death.

POTENTIAL GOAL NUMBER 5: Spreading the universal ideals of the French Revolution and helping to protect freedom, equality and